

A FREE CHAPTER FROM

# The Cracks Beneath *the Surface*

*Unmasking the Lies, Confronting the Pain, and Finding God in the  
Midst of It All*

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Chapter One — The Beginning of It All

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# The Beginning of It All

## CHAPTER ONE

I lay in my bunk, staring at the ceiling, the cold walls of juvenile hall pressing in around me. **My mind wouldn't let me rest.** Sleep wasn't coming. How could it? The cell was quiet, but inside my head, **it was loud.**

I thought about everything. **Every choice, every mistake, every moment that had led me here.** But the truth was, I didn't really start here, not in this place, not in this moment. I started long before that.

I started in a home where love and chaos **existed in the same breath.**

People say childhood shapes you. I don't know if I ever really understood what that meant until now, lying in this cell, realizing I had spent my entire life reacting to things I never had control over.

I wasn't born broken.

But the cracks started early.

I can still hear the voices. My parents' voices—raised, sharp, cutting through the walls like they were made of paper. **Their fights were like the weather, unpredictable but constant.** Some days, things were fine. Some days, they weren't. I learned early on to tell the difference, to listen to the tone of my father's voice when he walked through the door, to watch my mother's movements, to know when a storm was coming.

The cycle had stages.

First came **the** moments that made me believe maybe this time would be different. The laughter, the dinners together, the days at the river where I felt weightless, free, like a normal kid.

Then came **the tension**, the quick, sharp words between them, the looks, the silence that felt heavier than yelling.

Then, **the explosion**—the screaming, the doors slamming, the fights that felt like they would never end. **I can still hear it.** The sound of my mother crying, my father's anger filling every corner of our home.

And then, the part that hurt the most.

### **The silence after.**

That was the worst part.

Because it meant **everything would go back to normal like nothing had happened.**

No apologies. No explanations. Just another layer of pain added to a house already full of it.

And me? I just had to **exist in it.** I had to pretend it wasn't happening, pretend that I wasn't affected, pretend that I was okay.

But I wasn't okay.

I learned early that **my voice didn't matter.** That I could scream and beg them to stop, and they wouldn't. That no matter how much it hurt to watch, **I was powerless.**

And so, I stopped trying.

I stopped feeling.

I stopped believing in anything outside of survival.

Because that was what my home taught me—**that love was something unpredictable, something that could turn on you at any moment.** That strength wasn't about talking things out, it was about **who could yell loudest, who could hold their ground the longest, who could hurt the other person more.**

I didn't realize it then, but **I was already becoming them.**

Already learning that control came through force. That power came from fear. That to be heard, you had to **make people listen.**

Now, lying in this cell, I can see it so clearly. I can see the moments I absorbed those lessons without even knowing it. I can see how they shaped every decision I made, every reaction, every wall I built to protect myself.

I used to think that what happened to me as a kid didn't matter. That I was my own person, that I made my own choices, that **I had been in control this whole time.**

But I wasn't.

I had been following a script that was written for me before I even knew how to read it.

I had been **repeating the cycle, without even knowing I was part of it.**

I turned onto my side, pulling the thin blanket over me, but it didn't make the cold go away.

I thought about my father, about how I had spent my whole childhood **trying to prove something to him.** Trying to be tough, trying to be strong, trying to be everything I thought a man was supposed to be.

But what was a man supposed to be?

I didn't know.

I still don't.

All I knew was that the only thing I had ever really been taught was **how to survive.**

And that lesson had led me straight here.

Back to a cage.

Back to silence.

Back to the only thing I had ever known.

THE STORY DOESN'T END IN THAT CELL

# What happens when the cracks finally reach the surface — and God meets you there?

Chapter One is where the wound begins. The rest of the book is what it cost, how far down it went, and the grace that rewrote a story everyone thought was finished.

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*“Therefore, if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation.”*

*— 2 Corinthians 5:17*